CalorieCue

Calorie Counting Made Simple

A practical beginner's guide



01

Start with the basics

Calorie counting helps you notice patterns in what you eat. The goal is to make informed choices that fit your life.

What is a calorie?

A calorie is a unit of energy. Your body uses energy throughout the day, including at rest.

How it works

1. **Be aware** — Notice meals and portions.
2. **Keep it simple** — Choose a manageable method.
3. **Look at the big picture** — Focus on habits over time.



Practical tip

Start by noticing a typical day of eating.

02

Build a balanced plate

Use this flexible guide to bring variety to meals you enjoy.

Produce

Enjoy a variety of fruits and vegetables.



Protein

Try poultry, fish, eggs, tofu or beans.

Grains

Add rice, pasta, potatoes or whole grains.

Simple portion tips

- Include produce.
- Add a protein food.
- Adjust portions to your needs.

Meal tracker (preview)

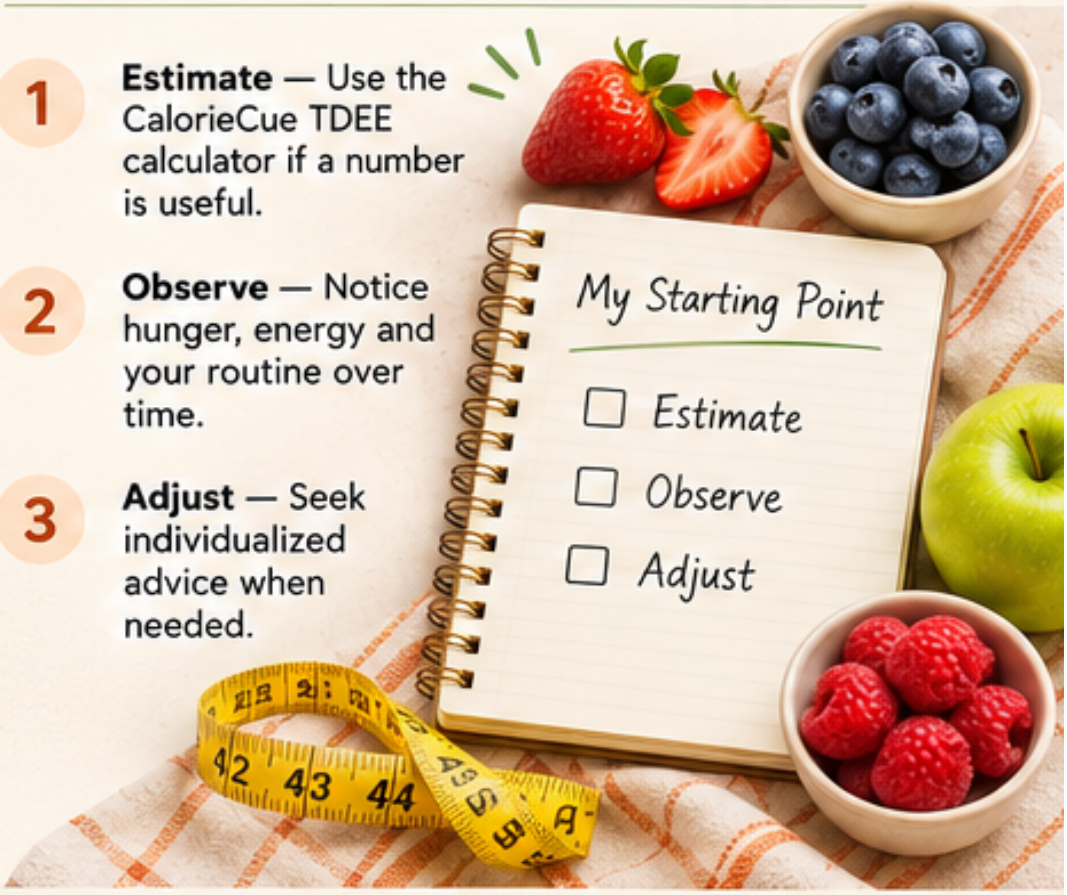
Meal	What I ate
Breakfast	☐
Lunch	☐
Dinner	☐
Snack	☐

03

Find your starting point

Your calorie needs depend on your body, activity and health. A calculator offers an estimate, not a prescription.

1. **Estimate** — Use the CalorieCue TDEE calculator if a number is useful.
2. **Observe** — Notice hunger, energy and your routine over time.
3. **Adjust** — Seek individualized advice when needed.



Practical tip

Avoid judging progress from a single day.

General education for adults. Seek professional advice for pregnancy, medical conditions or a history of disordered eating.

04

Portions made practical



Palm

A rough cue for protein foods.





Fist

A rough cue for a starch or fruit portion.





Thumb

A rough cue for fat-rich foods.





Two hands

A visual for vegetables or salad.



Practical tip

Hand sizes and food densities vary. These are visual cues, not calorie measurements.

05

Read the label



Check the serving first

The label describes one serving. Compare that with the amount you eat.

2 servings × 200 calories = 400 calories

Match your entry

Check the brand, serving weight and whether the food is raw or cooked.

Practical tip

A label serving is a reference amount, not a recommendation.

06

Everyday food reference

Approximate calories per listed serving

Proteins







FOOD	SERVING	CAL.
Chicken breast (grilled)	4 oz	185
Chicken thigh (skinless)	4 oz	235
Salmon fillet	4 oz	230
Tuna (canned in water)	4 oz	130
Shrimp	4 oz	120
Ground beef (90% lean)	4 oz	200
Ground turkey (93%)	4 oz	200
Sirloin steak	4 oz	230
Pork chop	4 oz	210
Eggs	2 large	140
Egg whites	3 large	50
Greek yogurt (nonfat)	1 cup	130
Cottage cheese (low-fat)	1 cup	180
Tofu (firm)	4 oz	95
Black beans	1 cup	220
Whey protein	1 scoop	120

Grains & Carbs





FOOD	SERVING	CAL.
White rice (cooked)	1 cup	206
Brown rice (cooked)	1 cup	215
Pasta (cooked)	1 cup	220
Quinoa (cooked)	1 cup	222
Whole wheat bread	1 slice	80
Bagel	1 medium	250
Oatmeal (cooked)	1 cup	154
Sweet potato	1 medium	103
Baked potato	1 medium	160
Corn tortilla	1	60
Flour tortilla	1 medium	140
Cereal (avg)	1 cup	150

Estimates vary with brand, preparation and portion. Check the label when available.

07

Everyday food reference

Approximate calories per listed serving

Fats & Nuts



FOOD	SERVING	CAL.
Avocado	½ medium	120
Olive oil	1 tbsp	120
Butter	1 tbsp	100
Almonds	1 oz (23)	164
Peanut butter	1 tbsp	95
Walnuts	1 oz	185
Cheddar cheese	1 oz	113
Mozzarella	1 oz	85
Cream cheese	1 tbsp	50
Mayonnaise	1 tbsp	90
Chia seeds	1 tbsp	60

Fruits & Vegetables



FOOD	SERVING	CAL.
Banana	1 medium	105
Apple	1 medium	95
Orange	1 medium	62
Strawberries	1 cup	50
Blueberries	1 cup	85
Grapes	1 cup	104
Broccoli	1 cup	55
Spinach (raw)	2 cups	15
Mixed greens	2 cups	20
Carrots	1 cup	50
Bell pepper	1 medium	30
Cucumber	1 cup	16

Estimates vary with brand, preparation and portion. Check the label when available.

08

Everyday food reference

Approximate calories per listed serving

Drinks



FOOD	SERVING	CAL.
Black coffee	8 oz	2
Latte (whole milk)	12 oz	180
Orange juice	8 oz	110
Whole milk	8 oz	150
Skim milk	8 oz	90
Almond milk (unsweet.)	8 oz	30
Soda (cola)	12 oz	140
Beer (regular)	12 oz	153
Wine	5 oz	125
Sweet tea	16 oz	180

Snacks & Treats



FOOD	SERVING	CAL.
Protein bar	1 bar	200–250
String cheese	1	80
Trail mix	⅓ cup	175
Tortilla chips	1 oz (10)	140
Potato chips	1 oz	155
Dark chocolate	1 oz	170
Popcorn (air-popped)	3 cups	100
Hummus	2 tbsp	70
Rice cake	1	35
Ice cream	½ cup	140

Condiments & Sauces



FOOD	SERVING	CAL.
Ketchup	1 tbsp	15
Mustard	1 tbsp	10
Soy sauce	1 tbsp	10
BBQ sauce	1 tbsp	30
Ranch dressing	2 tbsp	130
Salsa	2 tbsp	10
Honey	1 tbsp	64
Maple syrup	1 tbsp	52
Marinara sauce	½ cup	70

Estimates vary with brand, preparation and portion. Check the label when available.

09

Make meals satisfying



Breakfast

Eggs, Greek yogurt or tofu.



Lunch

Chicken, tuna, beans or lentils.



Dinner

Fish, lean meat, tofu or legumes.



Snack

Yogurt, cheese or edamame.

Simple swaps

Try sparkling water, yogurt as a creamy topping, or vegetables alongside a favorite dish.

Practical tip

Choose foods you enjoy. Compare labels when a calorie difference matters.

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Restaurants & real life



1. **Look ahead** — Check published nutrition information when available.
2. **Notice extras** — Sauces, oils, toppings and drinks affect estimates.
3. **Choose what you enjoy** — Consider a protein, produce and a satisfying side.
4. **Estimate and move on** — Portions and recipes vary.

Practical tip

One meal does not define your progress.

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Make it sustainable



Keep it manageable — Choose a routine you can return to.

Notice how you feel — Hunger, energy, mood and satisfaction matter.

Make room for life — Sleep, movement, stress and health also matter.

Practical tip

If tracking becomes stressful or rigid, take a break and seek support from a qualified professional.

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Your first week

Days 1–2: Notice
Record a typical day without judging it.

Days 3–4: Learn
Notice meals that satisfy you and moments that feel rushed.

Days 5–7: Try
Make one small change and reflect on what helped.



Practical tip
A missed entry is simply a missed entry. Resume when it feels useful.

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Your 7-day tracker

Day	Meals & portions	Notes
Monday		
Tuesday		
Wednesday		
Thursday		
Friday		
Saturday		
Sunday		

What felt easy?

What would help next week?

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Keep learning



- **USDA MyPlate —**
  Food groups and balanced meals.
  myplate.gov
- **FDA Nutrition Facts —**
  Serving sizes and labels.
  fda.gov/food/nutrition-facts-label
- **CDC Healthy Weight —**
  Nutrition, activity and habits.
  cdc.gov/healthy-weight-growth
- **CalorieCue —**
  Daily energy estimate.
  caloriecue.app/tdee-calculator

Closing tip

Choose one idea to try this week.
Adjust it until it works for you.

Review draft. Food-reference estimates require a final source and serving-size audit before publication.